

Up until Windows 2.0, users had to use the boring MS-DOS Executive to manage files and run their programs. In Windows 3.0, Microsoft introduced the Program Manager and File Manager, simplifying things a little. It also brought all your system configuration options under one roof—the Control Panel. Apart from the Control Panel that we know so well, Windows 3.0 also saw the birth of one of the most popular games of all time—Solitaire!

In 1991, Microsoft brought multimedia support for Windows 3.0, called Multimedia Extensions 1.0. It gave Windows support for CD ROM Drives and Sound Cards. It also contained a basic CD Player application for Windows.

Windows 3.0 was still buggy, and had little support for networks, leading Microsoft to its next step.

The ongoing struggle—the Windows 3.1 family

In 1992, Microsoft released Windows 3.1, which addressed many user and developer brickbats. For the developer, Microsoft gave a big, comprehensive API (Application Programming Interface), which simplified the task of creating user interfaces and let them focus more time on developing the core functionality of software.

On the visual front, Microsoft introduced the TrueType font system, which led it to be taken seriously for Desktop Publication. They also brought us another favourite—Minesweeper. It also integrated the multimedia support which had only been offered as a separate add-on to Windows 3.0.

In 1993, Windows for Workgroups 3.1 was released, which added support for networking and file and printer sharing. It also added Microsoft Mail—a pro-



Windows 3.1 - a spiffier version of Windows 3.0